

Pursue Her After You Have Her

There's a difference between the time you gave your wife and the time she actually got. The gap between those two is small enough to miss for years.

She asks if you want to watch a show together. You sit down beside her, and your phone stays in your hand. Halfway through she laughs at something and looks over to see if you caught it. You didn't.

Another night you take her to dinner. You chose the place and made the reservation. Then you spend most of the meal turning over a problem at work. You answer her questions. You aren't really there.

You made time for her both nights, and that counts for something. What she wanted was your attention, and you had it somewhere else.

When the effort changed.

Think about how you acted when you were still hoping she'd say yes to another date. You paid attention to what she enjoyed. You remembered the story about her friend. You brought her something she'd mentioned liking once, and you found places you thought she'd want to go.

Marriage lets you relax, and that's a good thing. You can sit quietly without wondering whether she's losing interest. You know you'll see her tomorrow. That security is a good part of the life you built. It can also make effort feel optional, until you're giving her less than you gave a woman you weren't sure would stay.

So you worked to win her, then treated the wedding as proof the work was finished. You still love her. You may have quietly stopped spending any

thought on her.

Epictetus has a rule for this in his Handbook, the *Enchiridion*: “Duties are universally measured by relations.” (*Enchiridion* 30, Long trans.) He was writing about fathers and brothers, but the shape fits a husband. Husband is a role you keep playing, not a title you won once. If you want to be her husband, keep being her husband. You were her suitor before she said yes, and that job stayed open. Loving her on your wedding day cost you nothing the following spring. Choosing her this Saturday costs you an afternoon, and an afternoon is the version she can see.

The date you can't plan.

Say you decide to take her out after twelve years, and you want to arrange the whole thing yourself.

The first place that comes to mind is the Italian restaurant she loved when you were dating. Then you try to remember the last time she ordered pasta, and you can't. You know what she liked at twenty-six. You can't name one thing she'd be excited about this Saturday.

So you ask her. She says she'd rather drive out to the lake town an hour north, walk around, and stop wherever looks good. Then she tells you why. She's been saving pictures of a garden she wants to build along the back fence, and there's a nursery up there she's been reading about.

You didn't know that. She's been mentioning small pieces of it for months, and you've been hearing her the way you hear the radio.

The date is the easy part. The following Tuesday, you ask where the first bed is going, and she takes you out in the dark with her phone light to show you the corner she's picked. Nothing about that evening was on the calendar. It happened because you finally heard something, and then came back to it.

She's changed across the years you spent in the same house. You've changed too. Asking is useful. Remembering the answer is what she notices.

What it looks like from her side.

When the effort stops, she usually decides she's been accounted for. She's the one who'll be there, so she isn't the one who gets planned around. The plain word for that is being taken for granted, and it feels less like a fight than like being furniture in her own marriage: known, needed, walked past.

She stops mentioning what she wants, because bringing it up twice was already more than she wanted to do. She organizes her own birthday. She says "whatever you want" because choosing got her nowhere the last three times. She never announces any of it. You end up with a wife who has gotten used to asking for less.

When you finally do plan something, she may not light up the way you pictured. Give it time. She's working out whether this is a change or just an evening.

Be there for the time you share.

If she wants to watch a show, put the phone in a drawer. You don't have to love the show. You can enjoy sitting beside her, seeing what makes her laugh, and letting an hour belong to the two of you. At dinner, the problem at work can wait until the drive home.

It isn't only about talking. Some nights she wants to tell you about her day. Some nights she wants your company while neither of you says much. You can tell which one it is when you're paying attention. If your mind wanders, come back to the table. You won't give her every minute perfectly, but you can give her the evening you offered.

She handled something hard this week and you noticed. She has no way of knowing that unless you say it out loud. The same goes for the work nobody else saw, and for the moment you looked over and thought she was beautiful. Familiar affection doesn't get less true because you've said it before.

Touch carries its own message, when she wants it. Reach for her hand on a walk. Sit close enough on the couch that she can feel you're there. Find out whether a hug is what helps at the end of a hard day, rather than assuming it is.

You met the five love languages a chapter ago: time together, words, service, gifts, touch. Use it as an inventory of what you've let fall away. If you mostly tell her you love her, what hasn't she gotten in a year?

Do the thing before she asks.

Maybe acts of service are what land best with her. You can ask what would help, and you should listen when she answers. But if every kind thing you do starts with her noticing a task, naming it, and reminding you about it, she's still carrying the part that wears her out: keeping track.

You already know the ordinary work of your house. The dishes are visible. Her car is low on gas. There was an errand she mentioned yesterday. Do it because her day gets easier, then let it go without announcing it and without standing beside the finished task waiting for something. A favor handed over with resentment can leave her wishing she'd done it herself.

You won't guess right every time. She may want to handle something you thought you were rescuing her from. Let her tell you. Taking initiative means being willing to notice and learn. You don't know her business better than she does. When she does ask, say yes generously. She can ask. She shouldn't have to ask for everything.

Gifts run on the same attention. Once the money is shared, a present from the joint account can feel pointless. She could have bought it herself. You were telling her she was on your mind while she wasn't in the room.

She pointed out a book weeks ago. She loves a particular pastry and never stops for one. You heard her, you thought of it on a Friday, and you brought it home. A note left where she'll find it does the same work and costs nothing.

Keep romance off the schedule.

Can you name the last romantic thing you did for her? Not the last date you took her on. A date is one evening; this is wider than that. If you have to count back through months to find one, you've found your starting place.

Romance in your marriage might be breakfast made before she's up, a letter, or an afternoon planned around something she likes now. The bar is knowing her well enough that an ordinary gesture is unmistakably hers. Nothing about it has to be grand.

She told you Monday that the review was Wednesday. Asking how it went on Wednesday night is the part she'd notice. She mentioned a restaurant she wants to try, and her favorite flowers aren't the ones you bought five years ago. Remembering only reaches her when it changes what you do.

Anniversaries and Valentine's Day lose their meaning when you handle them by rote. Ten minutes from home you swing into Walgreens for whatever card is left and a box of chocolate that's been on the shelf since Christmas. You remembered the date. You gave almost no thought to the woman you were celebrating. The same money, spent a week earlier, buys an evening she'd actually want. Plan the dinner she'd enjoy. Write down one memory that still makes you glad you married her. Start early enough to mean it.

Some years are crowded and hard. You may both be too tired to plan anything, and a quiet evening at home is the honest version of the day. You don't owe the calendar a performance. What's worth watching is whether thoughtfulness has gone rare everywhere else too.

Don't let knowing her end your learning about her.

Esther Perel is a therapist who writes about desire in long relationships. Her argument is that familiarity can settle into routine, and that curiosity and new experience help keep desire alive. You don't have to manufacture excitement every week. You do have to leave room for the woman beside you to surprise you.

In Letter 58 of his letters to his friend Lucilius, the Roman Stoic Seneca borrows an image from an older philosopher, Heraclitus. You recognize a river, and its water is never the same water. You've met that river in this book as the man who keeps his direction while the water changes around him. Seneca pointed it at the person next to you. Some of what she wanted when you met still matters to her. Some of it doesn't, and she may not have announced the difference.

Tsapelas, Aron and Orbuch published a 2009 analysis of couples followed for sixteen years. Spouses who called their marriage boring in year seven reported less satisfaction nine years later, even after the researchers accounted for how satisfied those spouses had been to start with. Every couple in it was still married at year sixteen. That's a pattern worth watching. It says nothing about your marriage in particular. The show you watch every week can be familiar and good. What wears on a marriage is going through every shared hour as though there were nothing left to find out.

Put the phone down, and give her the evening you came to share.

Keep choosing her in ways she can see

when you were dating	now
time together	
words	
service	
gifts	
touch	

Husband is a role you keep playing.

Chapter 13 Distillation — Pursue Her After You Have Her

Mechanism: Keep choosing her in ways she can see

Conversation sentence: You can love your wife and still let the effort that once made her feel chosen disappear from ordinary days.

Pursuit after marriage is attention you give her while you're together and thought you give her while you're apart. A man planning a date after twelve years can find he no longer knows what she'd want to do, because he stopped learning her somewhere along the way. When the effort stops, she usually decides she's been accounted for: taken for granted, needed and walked past, and she answers by asking for less. Put down the phone. Notice a task and carry it through without making her manage it. Say what you admire, offer the touch she welcomes, remember a preference, bring home a small gift, and plan time she would enjoy now. Familiar routines can be lovely; a marriage still needs room for curiosity and gestures that show you meant them.

Lesson: Winning her affection began a life of continuing to show care through presence, initiative, and romance.

Challenge: Name the last romantic thing you did for her. If you have to reach back months, choose one thoughtful action and follow through without assigning her the planning.

PRACTICE

1. Once a week, choose one thing she would enjoy or benefit from based on something you noticed. Plan and carry it through yourself, whether it is an errand, a small gift, or time together.
2. When she invites you to spend time together, put your phone away and give her your attention. If your mind wanders, come back to the moment you agreed to share.
3. Before an anniversary or Valentine's Day, recall something she enjoys now and plan a gesture around it. Give yourself enough time to make it personal.